

FOCAL POINT

FOR FILMMAKERS, BY FILMMAKERS

VANCOUVER
NOVEMBER 2025

HYPNOS LULLABY

READ OUR
FOCAL POINT
EXCLUSIVE

ONE ROOM, FOUR WAYS

HOW TO SET
DECORATE
ANYTHING

HIDDEN FILMING LOCATIONS

AND MORE...

MEET THE DIRECTOR

JOIN THE CREW

GET ON SET



01.

Hidden Filming
Locations Around
Vancouver

02.

Building Worlds
Inside Four Walls

03.

The Ones
Who Stay in
the Station
Watching the
Trains Leave |
An Analysis of
Guerros

04.

Indie
Spotlight:
Hypnos Lullaby

05.

So...
You're Dating
a Filmmaker

FROM THE EDITOR

Welcome to the very first issue of Focal Point Magazine.

I say “first” with equal parts pride and uncertainty—not because I doubt this project, but because independent filmmaking has taught me that nothing is guaranteed, not the next budget, not the next gig, not even the next issue of a magazine you made on pure love and late nights. What is guaranteed, though, is the joy of creating something with the people who inspire you.

My name is Ayilya, and I’m one of the filmmakers lucky enough to have formed genuine friendships with everyone featured in these pages. This magazine grew out of that community—out of the long days on set, the delirious 3 a.m. wrap conversations, the shared coffees, the shared chaos, and the shared dreams. It’s a small tribute to the people who make filmmaking feel less like a career path and more like a calling.

Independent filmmaking is a hustle—every filmmaker knows that. It’s often unpaid, usually unpredictable, and occasionally a little bit unhinged. But we do it anyway. We show up with aching backs and wild ideas. We haul gear in the rain. We negotiate locations at the eleventh hour. We figure out lunch somehow. And then, inevitably, we all end up together on set, whispering and laughing until the assistant director calls, “Quiet on set!” And just like that, the magic begins.

This issue celebrates that magic—the people who chase it, the stories they tell, and the world they build with nothing but persistence, passion, and a camera.

Whether this is a one-off project or the start of something bigger, I’m grateful you’re here holding this piece of our little universe. Here’s to this project, and maybe—hopefully—many more to come.

Cheers,
Ayilya
Editor, Focal Point Magazine



*Photo by
Ayilya Thampuran*



IOCO GHOST TOWN



Once a bustling oil company town, Ioco is now a ghost town. Founded in 1920, Ioco was a company town for the Imperial Oil Corporation.



There now lies a quiet maze of fading houses and overgrown roads. Its decay creates a stage for post apocalyptic stories.



Downtown New Westminster includes heritage architecture, riverfront boardwalks, and gritty lanes.



NEW WEST ALLEYS



BUNTZEN LAKE, ANMORE



A creepy landmark as seen on LAKE placid, the X-FILES, and IT.



Built in the early 1900s, the Buntzen Lake Powerhouses channeled mountain water to generate electricity for Vancouver.

HIDDEN

FILMING LOCATIONS IN AND AROUND VANCOUVER

AYILYA THAMPURAN

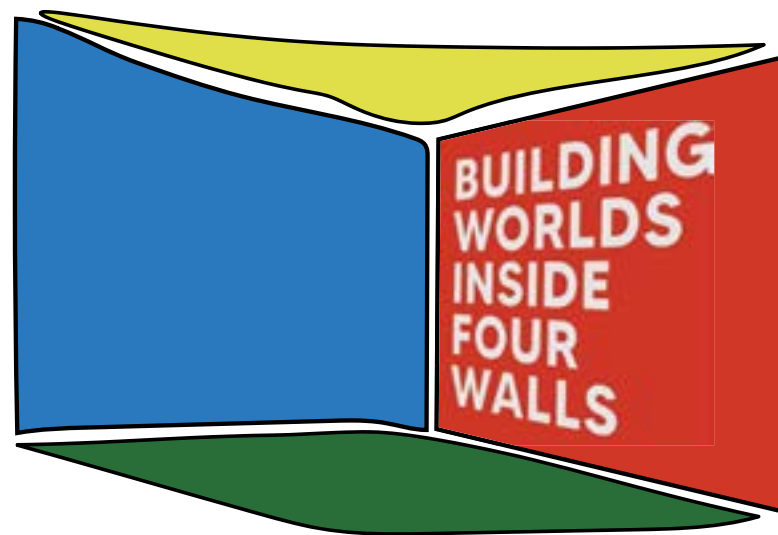
Photos by

Eve Lazarus, City of Port Moody, Creative BC

Half the best shots in the city are the ones you weren't supposed to get. Vancouver has long been nicknamed "Hollywood North" for good reason. Major productions, TV shows and independent features alike flock here for its diverse landscapes, skilled crews and favourable incentives. But while many location-hunters know the big draws — Stanley Park, Granville Island, Gastown — the real gold lies in hidden spots that feel fresh, less used, and suit indie budgets and flexibility.

For indie filmmakers, the eternal question is whether to ask permission or move fast and pray no one asks questions.

Guerilla shooting can save time and money, but it requires respect and common sense: keep your footprint small, your crew tight, and your gear minimal. If you're blocking sidewalks, using lights, or capturing sound that carries, it's worth approaching nearby businesses or property owners — you'd be surprised how many say yes when you ask sincerely and explain you're a small production. Vancouver is full of people who love movies, and sometimes a quick conversation gets you more cooperation than any permit. The key is knowing when you can blend in and when transparency will save you from a shutdown mid-take.



A single room can transform into countless worlds through the magic of production design. With the right combination of color, texture, and objects, a bare space can shift from a teenage bedroom to a prison cell, from a minimalist tech den to a cozy Indian home. It's all about the story being told and how the environment reflects the character's emotions, class, and lifestyle. For instance, the same four walls could house a messy artist's studio filled with paint-splattered canvases and unmade beds, or a polished modern apartment with sleek furniture and warm lighting. Even subtle changes—like switching fluorescent lights to tungsten bulbs, replacing posters with vintage paintings, or scattering worn-out props—can completely alter the atmosphere.

To achieve a convincing look, think about how every detail tells part of the story. Choose furniture that feels lived-in, not just pretty. Use textures—rough wood, chipped paint, faded fabrics—to suggest history and character. Layer your set with small personal props: half-read books, cluttered tables, mismatched dishes, and framed photos. When painting, pick colors that enhance mood—cool tones for isolation, warm ones for comfort, and bold splashes for drama. Natural light and practical lamps can elevate realism, while small imperfections make the space believable. To source affordable decor, check Facebook Marketplace, Craigslist, local thrift stores, or borrow from friends and family.

ONE



ROOM



MANY



MANY



MANY

DIFFERENT



WAYS.

GÜEROS

Alonso Ruizpalacio's debut feature film Güeros (2014) is the living proof that Mexican contemporary cinema is not dead; and it not only survives, but flourishes thanks to independent filmmaking.

BY MARÍA ESTRADA
ART AND FILM HISTORIAN
BASED IN VANCOUVER

Winner of the Best First Feature Award at the Berlin International Film Festival, *Güeros* was produced with the help of the FOPROCINE (now FOCINE), a Mexican subsidy awarded to one selected screenplay yearly to enable its production and distribution. Young Ruizpalacios didn't waste this opportunity to delve into the inner worlds of brothers Sombra (Tenoch Huerta) and Tomás (Sebastián Aguirre) as they navigate the chaotic streets of Mexico City trying to find their place in the world outside.

Shot in black and white and a 4:3 format, the film follows Tomás, a troubling teen from Veracruz who is sent to live with his older brother Sombra in Mexico City, but when he arrives, he finds out that Sombra and his friend Santos (Leonardo Ortizgris) have been living in a state of confinement and stagnation ever since the students from their university went into strike,

refusing to neither be a part of the movement nor against it, they remain paralyzed in their in-betweenness. When Tomás reads in the paper that the legendary rockstar Epigmenio Cruz has been hospitalized and might be passing soon, he convinces Sombra and Santos to go look for him, as an old cassette of his music is the only thing they have left from his absent father who affirmed that "it made Bob Dylan cry". With this mission, they embark on a road trip through the city, suddenly becoming aware of the movement that flows nonstop outside their static apartment. Throughout their trip, Tomás carries a camera with him and occasionally takes snapshots of things that interest him, one of the many subtle details in the film that highlights the importance of looking in the brothers' coming-of-age journey.

This concept is introduced to us since early in the film, when Tomás arrives at Mexico City and a title screen reads SUR (SOUTH) with a drawing of multiple disembodied eyes in the background, anticipating Sombra and Santos's static observant states before

leaving their apartment and Tomás's observation of the inside and outside worlds. In this claustrophobic episode of the story, we are also made aware of the outside events, namely the student strike, through images, as Tomás sees a picture in the paper of multiple kneeled students with their hands behind their heads as they are being subjected by policemen, with a header that reads "163 days of strike: 'the conditions are not in negotiation' say arrested students". While they remain confined in their apartment, they are only in contact with the simulacrum of events, and it is until they leave that they become active observants and participants of these events. This sentiment is also expressed when we are first introduced to the characters of Sombra and Santos, as Santos is talking about the "famous picture of a girl in Africa next to a vulture waiting for her to die and eat her", referring to the infamous Kevin Carter photography, and his suicide after winning the Pulitzer prize. Here too, the role of the static observer is condemned, implicitly condemning Santos and Sombra for remaining static observers of the strike, and the rest of the world outside.



Still from Güeros (2014)

When Sombra, Tomás, and Santos finally leave the apartment, their transformation from static observers to active ones becomes more evident as Tomás starts taking pictures with his camera. Throughout the trip, we see him take three pictures in different situations that mark their process of

finding Epigmenio, and in the way, finding themselves. The first picture he takes is of the empty hospital bed that Epigmenio occupied before he left the hospital. In this scene, a doctor (played by Ruizpalacios himself) tells them a story of a man that robbed a bus he was riding and how later that same man was brought to him in the ER because he had just been shot. The doctor gets



Still from Güeros (2014)

interrupted and doesn't finish the story, but this moment at the hospital gives the young men a reflection about the fleetingness of life, the imminence of death, and our interconnectedness in that cycle. Tomás's picture of Epigmenio's empty hospital bed reminds us of that imminence, and not only the little time they have to find him, but the shortness of life itself.

The second picture Tomás takes is of the traffic slowly moving behind them as they ride the car with Ana (Ilse Salas), an active member of the strike and Sombra's crush. They are listening to the obituary announcement of a businessman on the radio, and Ana asks, "would anyone notice if we were dead?". Sombra suddenly stops the car in the middle of the road and Ana quickly turns the car off. The cars behind them start honking desperately, but everyone in the car seems unbothered, watching how the cars angrily move past them.

In the next scene, the car is advancing again, but suddenly some kids throw a brick at them from a pedestrian bridge, forcing them to stop. When Sombra grabs the kid that threw the brick, he gets him into the car and tells him to show them where he lives so he can pay for the broken windscreen. As they drive, Tomás recognizes a pulque shop that a former lover of Epigmenio talked about, where they finally find him. Both these scenes in the car, expose first the power of will and the young friends' agency over their movement or stillness in life, but then show them the unexpectedness of some situations, and their powerlessness over fate and destiny.



Still from Güeros (2014)

Tomás's last picture is of particular importance, as it is the last image of the film. After meeting Epigmenio and Sombra finally confessing his love to Ana, the group find themselves driving very near the strike march. Ana unhesitatingly jumps out of the car and joins them, and Sombra follows her until he realizes he is in the middle of the march. Tomás calls for him from the car and, when Sombra looks back at him, both realize that they have finally found their

place as active observers.

This is also beautifully expressed moments earlier, when they finally meet Epigmenio, and in a long explanation of the ordeal they went through to find him, Sombra says, "My father said that if the world is a train station and the people are the passengers, the

poets are not the ones who come and go, but the

ones who stay in the station watching the trains leave". Sombra and Tomás finally understand that in this nonstop world, to become active observers as a way to understand and participate in the world, is also an act of resistance. To transcend the line between static and active observation is to reclaim our place in the world. Finally, Tomás takes his last picture: Sombra smiling, surrounded by the crowd and the endless movement.



hypnos lullaby

Filmed over 11 intense days across more than ten Vancouver locations, the pilot brought together more than fifty emerging filmmakers united by an ambitious vision.

What began as a story about a fractured mind slowly expanded into one of the most visually and logistically complex indie pilots of the year. Written and directed by Mikel Estrada, and shot by Ayilya Thampuran, Hypnos Lullaby demanded a scale rarely attempted in independent filmmaking: intricate prison sequences, dreamlike set transformations, and extensive visual effects.

Focal Point Magazine had the opportunity to gather insights directly from the core team behind Hypnos Lullaby.

INDIE FEATURE OF
THE WEEK



THE MAKING OF EPISODE 1: WHERE DREAMS COME TO DIE

In a dystopian world where dreaming is outlawed and dreamers become dangerously violent, Joseph a rookie prison guard wakes up from a dream. On his first day at a maximum security prison, he is tasked with transferring a notorious dreamer alongside his seasoned partner. Joseph must confront the disturbing reality of his subconscious while navigating a system that punishes those who dream.

CONCEPT ART BY
MIKEL ESTRADA

4. INT. ST. MATRISS STATE PRISON OFFICE -DAY

BOWMAN (30s) is sitting in front of FITZBURG'S (50s) desk as he smokes a cigar while FITZBURG'S angry voice is drowned as BOWMAN doesn't pay attention to him.

FITZBURG

Bowman? Bowman, dammit, can you hear me?

BOWMAN is closely observing how his cigar's smoke floats upwards until it reaches the ceiling fan and is finally dispersed by it. FITZBURG'S voice is suddenly loud and clear.

FITZBURG (CONT'D)

BOWMAN!

Writer & Director

MIKEL ESTRADA

It is overwhelming really , when you think about it you are creating a whole world, one that will exist forever, limited only by the lens of your vision, let me explain:

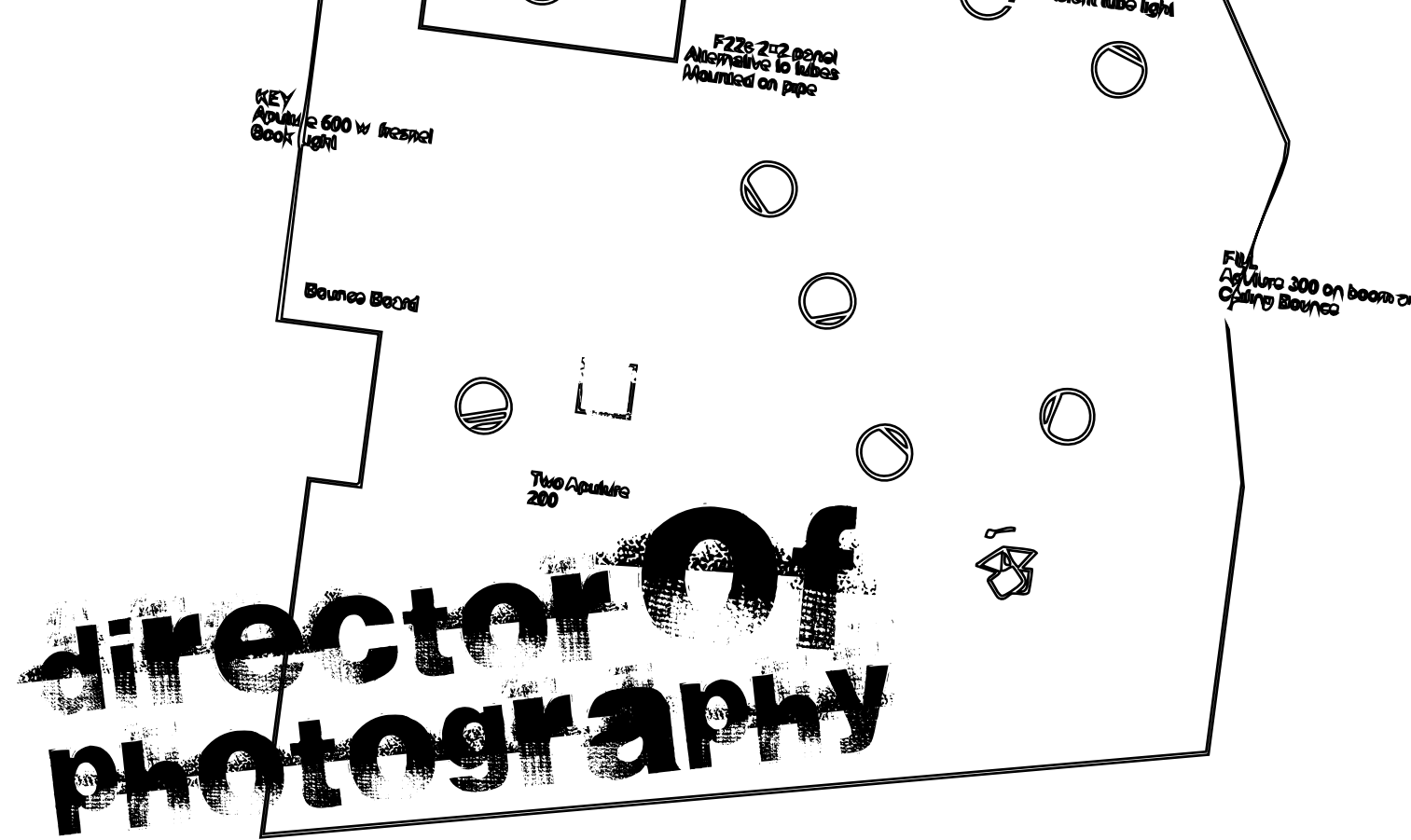
There are a million actors in the world, each capable of saying a million different lines, dressed in a million possible costumes, standing on a million different stages. But only one of those combinations will ever be captured , fixed in time , for the whole world to see.

And in that truth lies, at least in my opinion, the soul of the independent filmmaker. No one is freer, since only they can look at all the possible combinations and truly get to consider them for what they are. Unlike the big studios, where countless voices restrict paths because of branding, politics, or fear of backlash, the independent filmmaker answers only to his own heart.

Ours is the freest voice of them all and all it takes is for the filmmaker to expose everything of himself, reputation, image, and, ultimately, soul.

It feels strange to put into words what I experienced while directing an independent project. In a way, directing is something that should come naturally to everyone, after all we all do it all the time, even subconsciously.

When you tell your barber the exact haircut that will make you feel like a million bucks, when you give your tailor notes because your favorite pants are just a touch too short or when you ask for your ham to be sliced thin because anything thicker just feels wrong... All of these moments start the same way: with a vision, your vision. And from there, it's up to you to communicate it clearly to the people who will help bring that vision to life.



AYILYA THAMPURAN

Working on Hypnos Lullaby was the kind of experience that reminds you why you choose filmmaking even on the days it makes absolutely no sense. I walked into this project knowing it would challenge me—creatively, technically, and emotionally—but I didn't expect it to shape me the way it did. We were often racing against the sun, the rain, and the clock. Every frame became a puzzle of light, shadow, and movement.

This film lives in two spaces at once: a grounded, messy reality and a surreal dreamworld that constantly bleeds into it. From day one, my goal was to create a visual language that held both. Our lighting approach became a blend of controlled chaos.

We also had to “cheat” a lot of crowd energy into the frame, especially in scenes meant to feel packed, loud, and overwhelming. Indie sets don't always come with 50 background actors, so we used tight lenses and strategic blocking. Ten people became thirty, simply by how we framed them.

Some days were heavy. There were nights when I got home with my shoulders on fire, memory cards full, and one million thoughts still buzzing. But I can't wait for the world to see what we created. It was a reminder of why I love cinematography. This film was powered by friendship and the stubborn belief that indie filmmakers can conjure beauty out of very little.



13A MCU Tree guy
slow tilt up body to face



13F Insert Tree guy
elongated shadow on wall



03C Medium Back
Eye level Static Inmates
gather around fight



05C MCU Shanbrung
through stacks of papers



04C M Fitzburg has
had enough of Bowman



VFX supervisor

AMSI COLIN & DIEGO

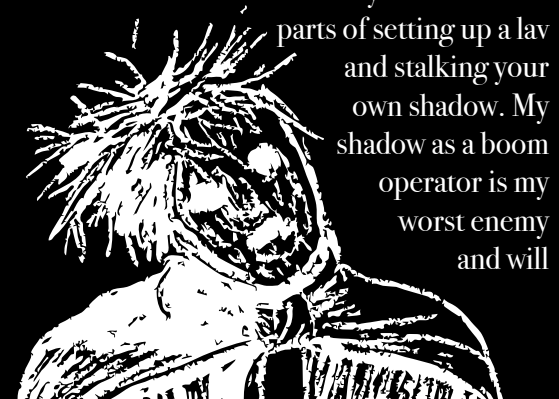
Working as a VFX Supervisor/Lighting and Compositing Artist for Hypnos Lullaby was both a challenging and gratifying experience. It involved planning how certain things had to be done all the way from the beginning stages in pre-production, and went all the way to overseeing and revising the work done in the visual effects pipeline. In between the aforementioned times were the production days, and being present on-set in all of the shooting days was a quite fun and remarkable experience since it really made one engaged in the process.

I could help with reducing times and costs by solving problems before they got into the post production stage, and also getting the expectations set. There was one particular shot where in a prison's lunch room set there were many actresses present at once and it even involved having a stunt coordinator on-set, which all made it a very memorable shoot. In addition, this sequence needed shots to be merged together in post production to create a crowded look, so it was definitely an interesting segment to see come together with the VFX process.

When the time of the post production stage came, me and my partner in the supervision and lighting/compositing department kept working closely alongside the director to create and maintain his vision. By managing production times, reviewing the work of each artist, and taking notes of the feedback of each one of them, we aided in carrying the necessary thoughts and intentions to fruition. The constraints of an independent production did not stop us from being able to work out solutions and even allowed us to explore and expand our knowledge in areas of many departments, all while maintaining a high visual quality and ultimately elevating the film's storytelling. It is immensely rewarding to have worked throughout the whole development in such an involved way to contribute in crafting the director's idea and bringing it to the big screen.



Off-set: My primary job is cleaning dialogue. Meaning that I'm more in charge of the technical aspect of the mix and less of the creative. Cleaning dialogue is like pottery classes, it's an art but a messy one. You don't want to do too much or else you could lose the natural integrity of someone's voice, but you don't want to do too little where the audience is distracted by wind or whatever natural sounds are overpowering the cast's dialogue. It's very much time consuming and I probably listen to the same clip about 40 times before it gets greenlit. It can be incredibly boring, but when you have the brief pleasure of listening to what it was compared to what it is now, it's very pleasing. Everything will be a lot neater, which is 90% of your job. Keeping things clean. The other 10%



constantly try to cause havoc by ending up in the shot. You gotta keep him away while being aware of where the cast is moving. Which makes knowing them and their process crucial! Nonetheless, when it's done right you get a pat on the back and get plenty of rest in-between takes.

On-set: The process was stressful; as many indie film shoots are. When you're working with a smaller budget, suddenly rain, wind and last minute changes become a lot more of an issue. Sound isn't something that can be ruined, because a bad sound will cost you your film. I like to think of sound (at least at the indie level) like breakfast. One of the most important meals of the day that nobody has time for. You have to make your own time, otherwise everyone will move on to the next shot. Usually, the sound person rocks the role by themselves and with all the gear, it can sometimes feel like carrying a comically large stack of plates. In spite of all these issues, if you familiarize yourself with all the provided material (script, schedule and shooting order) and persistently review your work over and over.



SO... YOU'RE DATING A FILMMAKER



Every film set has its unsung heroes — the people who hold boom poles, swap lenses, wrangle props, or stare intensely at a monitor... but there's another group quietly keeping productions alive: the partners of filmmakers. They are the sounding boards for early ideas, the stand-ins for last-minute rehearsals, the emergency drivers, the late-night prop pick up, and the ones who watch more strange indie films than they ever expected when entering the relationship.

For this issue of Focal Point, we wanted to step away from the camera and talk to the people who love the ones behind it. What does it mean to share life with someone whose mind is always breaking down shots, rewriting scenes, or waking up at 3 a.m. to whisper, "Wait—I just had an idea"?

We spoke to two partners of indie filmmakers — Viviana and Elisa — about how creativity shapes relationships, what life looks like on and off set, and the stories they've collected along the way.



VIVIANA - A REFLECTION

I met my partner when she was still just dreaming of becoming a filmmaker, living a very normal life, and the prospect of a regular 9-to-5 job. But her leap into filmmaking happened so fast that before I realized it, I was spending a random Tuesday acting as a long-fingered monster for strangers on set.

Somewhere along the way, she transformed into this passionate, full-of-life person who was constantly — and annoyingly — pausing and rewinding movies. That's when my unexpected film education began. She taught me how movies are made, what to look for, why certain shots matter, and suddenly I couldn't watch a film the same way again. I started appreciating them so much more.

But let me give you a friendly warning: the strange, experimental films your filmmaker partner discovers — the ones she swears are the last one, and this one is truly amazing — will absolutely not be the last you watch. And yes, my nightmares have evolved accordingly.

ELISA - A CONVERSATION

How did you first meet your partner? When did you realize filmmaking was such a big part of their life?

I met my partner when we were both in college, introduced by my sister. I realized films were a big part of his life right away because he loves watching movies, analyzing them, and finding out every fact about the story and the way it was made. But I realized filmmaking was such a big part of his life when he started writing his first script.

How do you get involved in their projects? Any fun stories you'd like to share?

I love hearing his ideas all through the process, from being the first one to give comments on the script to being there helping any way I can on set, and encouraging through post-production. A lot of fun stories happen on set, though some of them might be scary while they happen — like a bunch of water pouring in the middle of a set.

What's the proudest you've ever felt watching your partner's work?

I feel the proudest every time he feels proud of his work — when he's excited to tell me a story he just thought about, or when he really likes how a shot is turning out so he can't wait to show it to me.

What surprises you the most about being on set?

How many people and how much effort goes into just a couple minutes on screen. It is amazing.



Have there been moments that tested your patience?

Yes, especially during filming. It's more the people around the project that test my patience, since having strangers working on something your partner has put everything into can bring intense emotions when they do things wrong or don't put as much effort into the project.

Do you think being with a filmmaker has changed your relationship with movies or storytelling?

Of course. I used to see movies as just stories I was in for a couple of hours. Now I notice everything going on in the movie. I wonder how they filmed a specific shot, or where each software for VFX was used. I also notice the choice of music a lot more. I think of movies as stories actually created by so many people, which has its ups and downs.

How do you support each other during stressful production periods or creative slumps?

Just a lot of patience and communication. Every job involves stressful moments — you just need to understand the job to help your partner navigate theirs. And lots of pep talks work too.

FOCAL

POINT
STORIES
NEVER
STOP.

